

ISSUE 01 • OCT 2024 - MAR 2025

AMATHUBA

PROVIDING
OPPORTUNITIES



www.sedfa.org.za

A Sedfa Publication

Cover Page: Sedfa logo design winner, Matimba Mathye (middle), with Sedfa ACEO, Mr Nkosikhona Mbatha (left) & The Minister of Small Business Development, Ms Stella Tembisa Ndabeni (right).

Sedfa Newsletter – Amathuba – Providing Opportunities

The Small Enterprise Development and Finance Agency is proud to present to you the first edition of its quarterly newsletter, Amathuba. As the name implies, the newsletter serves to provide opportunities to Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs) by among others sharing their stories. The publication also seeks to inform the reader about small business issues with mutual interest to the MSMEs and Sedfa's stakeholders in the ecosystem.

Through this newsletter we aim to keep you, our customer and partner in the eco-system, up to date on exciting developments within the organisation and some of the ground breaking initiatives that are set to change the small business landscape in South Africa.

In this first issue we introduce the new Sedfa logo, marking a bold future to promote and coordinate the small enterprise ecosystem. We also show highlights of Sedfa key events throughout the provinces and internationally that took place from October 2024 to March 2025, **between page 3-32**. This includes Sedfa's Pitch for Funding Programme that seeks to give MSMEs an opportunity to Pitch to potential investors.

Another interesting programme is the Small Enterprise Coaching Programme that provides coaching and skills development for entrepreneurs over ten months, as well as the SheTrades programme that focuses on the development of women entrepreneurs.

Cooperatives also play a vital role in the economy of the country. In this publication, **on page 33**, we provide snippets of the Cooperative event that took place in October 2024 at the OR Tambo Protea Hotel

Sedfa also aims to keep our eco-system partners and the public informed on Micro Small Medium Enterprise and Cooperative information by sharing research on different topics that affect entrepreneurs. **Read on page 35.**

Editorial Team

Sedfa Unveils New Logo, Marking a Bold Future



On 10 December 2024 at Emperor's Palace Convention Centre, Sedfa revealed its new brand identity at the National Presidential MSME & Coops Post Awards Breakfast. The event, hosted by Donovan Goliath, brought together Sedfa officials, private sector partners, and top entrepreneurs to celebrate excellence in small business development.

Acting CEO Nkosikhona Mbatha described the logo as a symbol of growth, connection, and transformation, reinforcing Sedfa's role as both a funder and a business enabler:

"This logo tells a different story—one about the ecosystem and how we, as an entity, will coordinate and drive it as an enabler. We want this agency to embody a fusion of finance and business support, ensuring that the businesses we fund not only thrive but also receive the guidance and assistance they need throughout their journey."

In the spirit of fostering creativity and engagement, Sedfa hosted an internal Logo Design Competition, inviting employees to submit their vision of what the agency's new identity should represent.

The winning design, created by Matimba

Mathye, was selected for its strong alignment with Sedfa's mission and values.

Reflecting on the inspiration behind the design, Mr Mathye shared: "I wanted to create something that represents not just a logo, but a movement—an identity that symbolizes the journey of small businesses, from startup to success, with Sedfa as their guiding force."

His design stood out for its modern aesthetic, meaningful symbolism, and alignment with Sedfa's transformative role in the MSME sector.

Minister Stella Ndabeni-Abrahams further honored winners of the National Presidential MSME & Cooperatives Awards, with some entrepreneurs receiving unexpected funding cheques of up to R1.2 million.

With its fresh identity, Sedfa embarks on an exciting new chapter—one focused on supporting, uplifting, and transforming small businesses across South Africa.

[Click Here](#) to watch the National Presidential MSME & Coops Post Awards Breakfast and Sedfa Logo Reveal



SUCCESS STORY



Mochobo Executive Guards is a close corporation with three members, headquartered in Potchefstroom city center under the Tlokwe City Council. The business started informally in 2004 and the services offered included the following:

- Event security and crowd control
- VIP protection
- Physical security
- Electronic security
- Private investigations
- Marshaling services

Initially, the company operated from a residential property, lacking proper business premises and resources. Employment was limited to the three founding members, with earnings barely covering wages. In addition, without an operational or strategic business plan their growth was stagnant. In 2007, managing member Mr. Diphaphang Mochobo responded to a Seda advertisement for the SAPLATO mentorship program. An assessment done by Seda revealed the following key challenges in his businesses:

- Limited business management skills (financial management, marketing, administration)
- Low client base
- Lack of market penetration strategies
- Absence of quality management systems

Interventions & Solutions

Mochobo Executive Guards was enrolled in the 12-month SAPLATO program, equipping Mr. Mochobo with essential management skills and networking opportunities. Additional Seda support included:

- Business plan development
- Promotional and marketing material creation
- Business rebranding

By May 2022, the company was showcased at the Minister of Small Business Development Roadshow in Klerksdorp, recognized as a key success story for Sedfa.



“ All these interventions led to the company having **five additional branches** in Krugersdorp, Vereeniging, Welkom and Klerksdorp.”



The CEO of MEG Security Mr Mochobo, right, celebrating their milestone with a stakeholder.



Outcomes & Achievements

- 100% increase in turnover
- Established a strong brand, securing international cricket match security contracts in Potchefstroom
- Creation of 29 sustainable jobs
- Acquisition of a new business vehicle
- Mr. Mochobo was a provincial runner-up in the Seda Business Plan Competition, winning a business development voucher worth R50,000, a laptop, and R10,000 cash
- There was further Growth & Expansion in 2015 where the company underwent further assessments, leading to:
- Quality management system reviews
- Implementation of financial management systems
- Certification of quality management standards

All these interventions led to the company having five additional branches in Krugersdorp, Vereeniging, Welkom and Klerksdorp.

- 11 new clients secured
- 14 firearm licenses obtained
- Five additional vehicles purchased
- Revenue and profit increased by 100%
- Secured major contracts, including:
 - 12-month aviation security (Pilanesberg)
 - 36-month security and investigations (North West Gambling Board)
 - 12-month industrial security (Ngwathe Power Plant)
 - 36-month security contract (GP Department of Health)

Mochobo Executive Guards celebrated 20 years of black excellence in security on November 19, 2024.

Click [link](#) to watch video of Machobo Executive Guards video for the Klersdorp office opening.

ENTREPRENEURSHIP MONTH

MSMEs in Soweto receive working equipment from Minister Stella Tembisa Ndabeni

Minister Stella Tembisa Ndabeni, joined by Gauteng MEC for Economic Development Mr Lebogang Maile, handed over machinery and equipment to micro and informal traders in Soweto on the 11th December as part of the Informal and Micro Enterprise Development Programme (IMEDP).

At the Jabulani Safe Hub Complex, they engaged MSMEs and small business players, highlighting the importance of youth entrepreneurship. The Minister urged young people to use their skills to create businesses, inspired by a young animator who received technical recording and working equipment to expand his animation, photography, and cinematography business.

“The tools aim to enhance small enterprises’ productivity, sustainability, and contributions to the local economy.”



Minister Stella Tembisa Ndabeni addresses the community of Soweto



PROGRAMMES AND PARTNERSHIPS

Entrepreneurship in Schools Programme



The City Of Cape Town is set to implement entrepreneurship programmes in schools to equip learners with essential skills, knowledge, and confidence to become future business leaders. This exercise will contribute to the National Development Plan (NDP) 2030 vision that places the responsibility of creating 90% of all jobs on MSMEs. Currently, it is estimated that MSMEs create about 60% of all jobs. In most nations, MSMEs account for the most jobs in the economy. Therefore, in the South African context, promoting entrepreneurship in schools can significantly contribute to reducing youth unemployment by empowering learners with the skills and mindset needed to start and manage their own ventures.

The programme will provide learners with practical entrepreneurial skills, including business planning, financial literacy, marketing, and leadership, cultivating an entrepreneurial mindset by exposing students to successful entrepreneurs and innovative business ideas and encourage learners to develop business ideas that address local community needs, fostering a sense of entrepreneurship that contributes to economic development.

The program structure is as follows:

Workshops and Seminars: Conduct interactive workshops that cover key topics such as idea generation, business planning, marketing strategies, and financial management.

Mentorship Programmes: Pair learners with local entrepreneurs for guidance, support, and real-world insights.

Business Incubator: Create a platform within the school where learners can develop and test their business ideas.

Competitions and Showcases: Organise entrepreneurial competitions to encourage innovation and provide recognition for outstanding business ideas.

Implementation:

Partnerships: Collaborate with local businesses, and business hubs to provide resources and expertise.

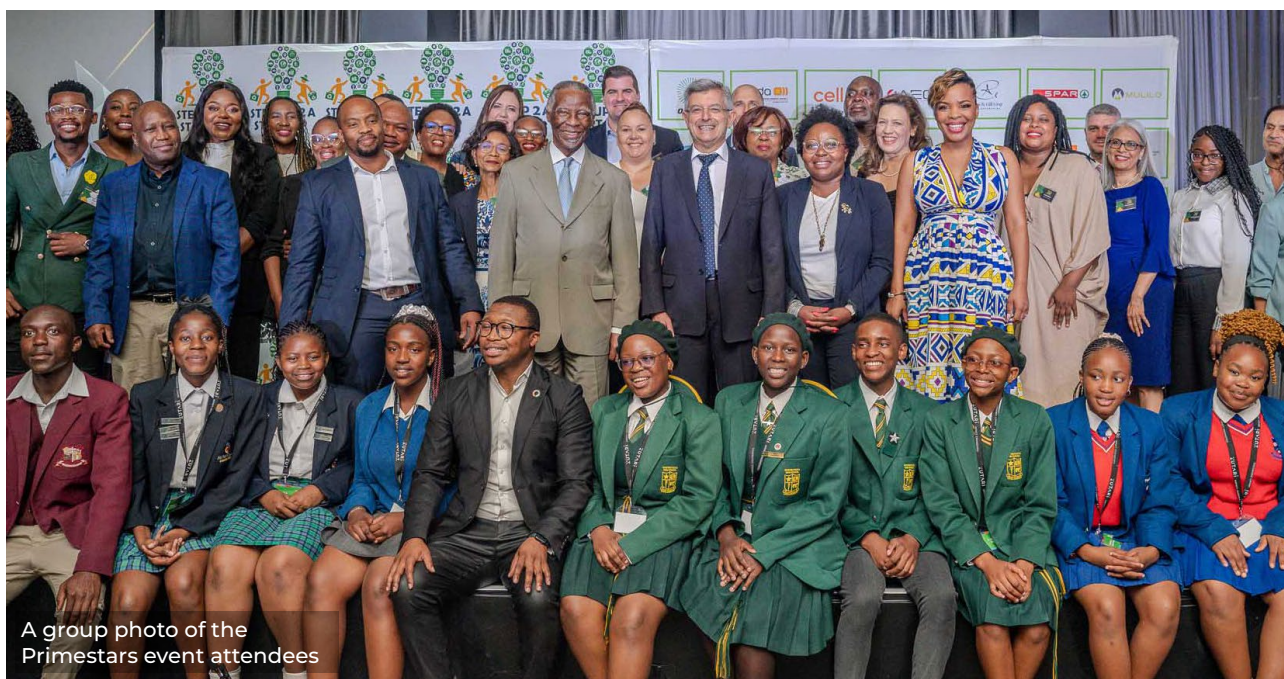
Curriculum Integration: Work with educational authorities to integrate entrepreneurship into their curriculum.

Training for Educators: Provide training for teachers to effectively deliver entrepreneurship education.



Entrepreneurship in Schools Programme Partnership

Sedfa in partnership with Primestars celebrates the top young entrepreneurs who participated in the Step Up to a Start Up Programme



A group photo of the Primestars event attendees

“We are taking the youth ‘From Schoolroom to Boardroom!’, empowering them to innovate, enhancing not only their own lives but also those of their communities and, on a broader scale, the country.” – Nkosinathi Moshoana, COO of Primestars and Executive Lead on the Step Up 2 A Green Start Up programme.

Raising young entrepreneurs for a changing climate, helping them harness their potential to create a greener future, is a pivotal moment in the fight against the climate change crisis. The National Youth Entrepreneurship Awards represent the culmination of the 2024 implementation of the Step Up 2 A Green Start Up programme.





In 1st Place: The Green Entrepreneurs from Marobathota High School in Boyne, Limpopo. Ramadimetja Chidi, Titelo Mashamaiti, and Tibuyile Maziya innovated by improving vendor stalls in their community with recycled cardboard. They were joined at the bootcamp by their educator, Mamushi Letsoalo.



In 2nd Place: Eco-Umbrella from Thabane High School in Kimberly, Northern Cape. Boingotlo Frans, Boitumelo Sekgopi, and Lesego Mojake empowered their community with a solar-powered umbrella. They were joined at the bootcamp by Tsholofelo Liphoko.



In 3rd Place: Eco Green Eco Synthesis from Afrika Tikkun Uthando Centre in Braamfontein, Gauteng. Honest Moyo, along with Mellisa Mpande and Nomusa Mathebula, tackled inadequate waste management in their community by developing solar-powered recycling bins. They were joined at the bootcamp by their educator Dimakatso Makhasane.

Former President of the Republic of South Africa, Mr Thabo Mbeki congratulates the winners

Each year, millions of rands in prizes are awarded, including bursaries, internships, seed funding, business mentorship, entrepreneurship development courses, and incubation.

Step Up to a Start-Up Programme Overview

The Step Up to a Start-Up initiative, co-led by YouthStart Foundation and Primestars, is a pioneering South African program designed to nurture entrepreneurship among high school learners with a focus on the green economy. Launched in 2014, this initiative addresses two critical challenges: youth unemployment and climate change. The latest version, Step Up 2 A Green Start-Up, aligns with South Africa's sustainability objectives by equipping youth with the skills to identify green business opportunities.

Origins and Inspiration

The program was launched in response to South Africa's high youth unemployment rate, currently close to 60% for those aged 15-34. It aims to shift the mindset from job-seeking to job-creation highlighting entrepreneurship as a sustainable solution to both economic and environmental challenges. Nkosinathi Moshwana, the Founding Director of YouthStart Foundation, has been instrumental in driving this vision.

Focus on the Green Economy and Climate Change

With the global push for climate action and the signing of the Climate Change Bill in South Africa, the Step Up 2 A Green Start-Up programme educates youth on how to address environmental challenges through sustainable entrepreneurship. Participants learn to view climate change as an opportunity to innovate, with a focus on environmental conservation and profitability. This is timely, as South Africa aims to create up to 275,000 green jobs by 2030, especially in the energy and agriculture sectors.

Program Goals and Implementation

The program inspires learners to transition from a fixed job-seeking

mindset to a growth-oriented, job-creating perspective. Through engaging formats such as film screenings, hands-on toolkits, and national competitions, YouthStart Foundation transforms the way learners perceive environmental issues as business opportunities.



The program reaches over 12,000 learners nationwide each year, significantly impacting urban, township, and rural communities. The top teams participate in a bootcamp to refine their green business ideas, culminating in pitches to industry experts.

Over the past decade, the program has engaged more than 100,000 learners, 6,000 teachers, and 2,000 high schools, focusing on underserved township and rural areas to provide entrepreneurial skills and green economy principles.





Importance and Impact

What distinguishes Step Up 2 A Start-Up is its commitment to bringing climate change education and entrepreneurial training to underserved areas. By targeting rural and township schools, YouthStart Foundation ensures that young people from these communities have equal access to opportunities in the green economy, helping bridge educational and economic disparities. The initiative has inspired a generation of ecopreneurs who prioritize sustainability, social responsibility, and economic resilience. Success stories from past participants, now running their own green businesses, testify to the program's transformative power.

Inspiring Green Entrepreneurs

The focus on sustainability has empowered thousands of young South Africans to become ecopreneurs. The program fosters a new generation of entrepreneurs who combine social and environmental impact with profit.

Development of a Strong Alumni Network

The Step-Up Alumni Network has become a significant milestone, providing ongoing support, mentorship, resources, and collaboration opportunities for alumni who have launched successful green businesses.

Empowering Marginalized Communities

By taking critical climate change education and entrepreneurial training to under-resourced areas, the program ensures that youth from these communities are not left behind in the green economy transition.

The Step Up 2 A Green Start-Up initiative is more than an educational project—it's a catalyst for change, empowering young people to shape South Africa's green future. The program continues to expand its reach, ensuring that all communities, especially those underserved, can access the opportunities within the green economy.

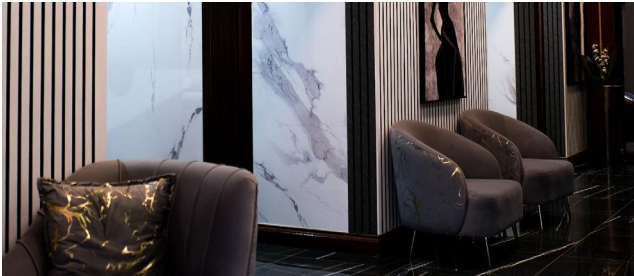
"As you navigate your path, remember that every small action you take today shapes the world of tomorrow." – Nkosinathi Moshona, COO of Primestars.

"To our 2024 participants: your ideas matter, and your dreams are valid." – Martin Sweet, MD of Primestars.

"The bootcamp wasn't for the faint-hearted. These young South Africans are ready to lead the way." – Refiloe Mohale, GM of The YouthStart Foundation.



Tourism Equity Fund - Opening Doors to Luxury and Opportunity



In the heart of Polokwane, a new gem is rising that reflects the bold spirit of entrepreneurship Sedfa is proud to support. **Atrium Boutique Hotel** is more than just a luxury hospitality destination—it's a story of vision, discipline, and the courage to dream bigger.

Founded by husband-and-wife duo Matodzi Joseph and Lesetja Johanna Mukwevho, Atrium Boutique Hotel is set to offer 26 luxury rooms, a 100-seater restaurant, boardrooms, a bar, and a full-service conference facility—all styled to earn a 4-star rating.

What makes this story especially inspiring is the Mukwevhos' journey. Once educators, they ventured into business over two decades ago. Today, they manage a thriving portfolio across fuel, retail, construction, property, and agriculture. Atrium is their latest venture—proof that with persistence and planning, diversification is possible.

“We wanted to create something elegant, welcoming, and proudly local. Atrium Boutique Hotel is not just a business—it's a legacy.”—
Matodzi Joseph Mukwevho,
Co-founder

Positioned near major educational institutions, hospitals, and event hubs,

the hotel is ideally located to serve both leisure and business travelers. It's expected to draw visitors attending events like the Mapungubwe Heritage Festival, Sapa Yopa Rally, and Limpopo Gospel Festival. With Polokwane seeing nearly 2 million tourists annually, the market potential is strong.

To bring Atrium to life, the founders combined their resources and tapped into various funding avenues—including a partnership with Sedfa. Their journey shows that while funding from specific initiatives like the Tourism Equity Fund (TEF) may be paused or delayed, other opportunities exist—Sedfa's broader support channels are open and accessible to qualifying MSMEs.

From architectural design to local job creation (19 permanent roles expected), this project showcases what Sedfa stands for: unlocking potential and building futures. If you've been thinking about expanding your business into hospitality—or launching your own dream project—Atrium Boutique Hotel is a shining example that it can be done. The team encourages aspiring entrepreneurs to explore Sedfa's funding programmes and take that first step toward building something unforgettable.

Sedfa is here. The opportunity is now.

Address: 28 Burger St, Polokwane Central, Polokwane, 0699
Phone: 015 880 2930



Sedfa ESD Private Sector Dialogue and Networking



Purpose

Sedfa hosted a series of private sector dialogues at district level, which were meant to discuss Enterprise and Supplier Development (ESD) engagement & collaboration to support the MSMEs & Cooperatives. The aim of these dialogues was to foster open communication, identify mutual goals, and develop actionable strategies for integrating MSMEs into corporate supply chains. The dialogues further aimed to assist the private sector to meet their Enterprise and Supplier Development (ESD) obligations under the Broad-Based Black Economic Empowerment (B-BBEE) framework.

During the month of September 2024, Seda, Sefa and the CBDA hosted 4 ESD dialogues (before the 3 entities were merged) covering the following districts: OR Tambo [EC], Amathole [EC], eThekweni [KZN] and John Taolo Gaetsewe [NC]. These dialogues were hosted using the Enterprise Development for Small Enterprise Programme funds and were targeting the private sector and SoEs.

Following the 4 dialogues, Sedfa management had identified 7 districts to implement all District Ecosystem Facilitator initiatives. It was therefore important to also host these dialogues at

the remaining 3 districts. The last round of these dialogues for the 2024/25 financial year were held at the remaining 3 districts which included Sarah Baartman District (Jeffreys Bay), and Chris Hani District (Queenstown). The Eastern Cape Province, and uMgungundlovu District (Pietermaritzburg), dialogues were conducted during March 2025.

Objectives

The events were aimed at accomplishing the following objectives:

- Strengthening and affirming existing formal relationships and partnerships with the private sector and SoEs;
- Fostering potential new partnerships with private sector & SoE entities;
- Showcasing Sedfa's various programmes, services and activities that could add value to these entities.
- Demonstrating Sedfa's capabilities and resources that can be harnessed to support private sector objectives via partnerships and other forms of collaboration; and
- Communicating and highlighting Sedfa's strategic ecosystem role.

The theme of the dialogues was "Leading Transformation



Together through Targeted SMME Development”

The theme captures the potential benefits and strength of working together in a strategic manner, targeting key industry sectors and specific MSMEs whilst focusing joint resources and effort on identified areas of economic activity - where there is high growth potential for MSMEs to be supported with compliance, business competitiveness and market access.



Invitees to the Dialogues

Categories of invitees included; Corporate and SoE Executives and Managers involved in ESD and related areas; Business Chambers, relevant Development Finance Institutions [DFIs], Provincial and Local Government Economic Development officials, DSBD national & provincial officials; Sedfa officials and District SMME Coordinating Council [DSCC] members.

Dialogue Deliberations

- Value proposition for partnering on Enterprise and Supplier Development [ESD] to address the needs of the private sector and MSMEs.
- Enterprise and Supplier Development [ESD] Community of Practice (CoP). An initiative of the DSBD and Sedfa which will be of interest to most private sector participants.
- DSBD Access to Market & Value Chain Support.

- Cooperative Banking Institutions (CBIs) and Cooperative Banks (CBs) - “user-owned” financial cooperatives.

Conclusion

The theme of these events, “Leading Transformation Together through Targeted SMME Development”, emphasised the fact that to address the issue of unemployment, inequality and poverty in South Africa, both the private and the public sector should join hands as “together, they can achieve more”.

The private sector representatives as well as the public sector officials who had honoured the invite, indicated that it was indeed a good idea for their companies to partner with Sedfa, to focus on joining resources and effort in terms of compliance, business competitiveness and market access for the high growth potential MSMEs. This, to increase the areas of economic activity within their districts.

A sentiment highlighted at all dialogues was that Sedfa must lead the ecosystem and continue hosting similar dialogues in the future.

It was clear in all the districts in which the dialogues took place that relations between Sedfa and the District Municipality are cordial and that it is better to ensure integrated service delivery by all the ecosystem players within the district. However, where relations seemed to be less pleasant, more frequent engagements are required by both sides as together, they can achieve more.

Further lessons learned was that monitoring of the issues that were raised at each of the dialogues by Sedfa’s regional branches would be critical.

The signing and/or renewing of agreements with the private sector to provide an integrated service was also deemed important to ensure the MSMEs within each district are serviced.

SheTradesZA Programme

Moedi Wines – Bee Loved Honey Feedback

Sedfa and SheTrades have played a pivotal role in empowering Moedi Wines, aiding in market readiness, mentorship-driven growth, and international market exposure.



Market Readiness

Sedfa's comprehensive programs equipped Moedi Wines with the tools needed to navigate the wine industry, refine their value proposition, and align with export demands. SheTrades contributed by enhancing the brand's understanding of gender-focused market trends, boosting its appeal to socially conscious buyers globally.

Mentorship

Mentorship from Sedfa and SheTrades shaped Moedi Wines' strategic direction. This guidance helped the brand expand into markets like Denmark, the UK, and the US, while building confidence and resilience in the competitive wine industry.

International Market Exposure

SheTrades' global network opened doors for Moedi Wines to participate in trade shows, virtual showcases, and B2B events, amplifying the brand's visibility on a global scale.

Impact on Moedi Wines

Through these collaborations, Moedi Wines has solidified its global presence and emphasized the potential of African female entrepreneurs in driving economic impact and social change.

She Trades HubZA: Women Entrepreneurs shine on the Global Stage



SheTradesZA hosted a roundtable to spotlight the International Trade Centre's (ICT) work through the She Trades Hub, facilitated by the Small Enterprise Development and Finance Agency (Sedfa). The event was held at the Menlyn Boutique in Pretoria which brought together beneficiaries to share their business success and highlights of the impact of their participation in the trade missions to Dubai and Mauritius, along with six months of mentorship.



The programme has had a transformative impact on its beneficiaries, empowering them to expand their operations and access international markets.

The following businesses took part in the roundtable:

Ms. Lesego Serolong, Founder of Bokamoso Foods:

Bokamoso Foods is dedicated to social impact through innovative business practices. Lesego is also the co-founder of Raise the Children International, a non-profit helping orphans access higher education.

SheTrades HubZA Win: Exporting to Denmark, the UK, and the US.

Ms. Mabel Akinlabi, CEO of Browns Group Pty Ltd:

Browns Foods, founded during the COVID pandemic, now employs 37 permanent staff.

SheTrades HubZA Win: Orders from Dubai and the US, pending new facilities and veterinary certification.

Crafters:

Setsong Tea Crafters produces indigenous tea, working with rural



Limpopo cooperatives to create jobs

SheTrades HubZA Win: Orders from Dubai and Botswana.

Colleen Flowers, CEO of Colleen's Handmade Sauces:

A producer of handcrafted sauces with a focus on organic ingredients and sustainability.



Department of Small Business Development, key stakeholders, Sedfa and She Trades Beneficiaries

Reema Maharaj, Owner of Marshalls Traditional Healthcare:

They have been manufacturers of traditional medicines since the 1930s, exporting to Mauritius and the US.

SheTrades HubZA Win: Exporting successfully to Mauritius and the US.

Retang Phaahla, CEO of Setsong Tea

SheTrades HubZA Win: First order shipped to the UAE.

These success stories highlight the programme's role in fostering global trade opportunities and driving sustainable growth for South African entrepreneurs.

Small Enterprise Coaching Programme (SECP)

Enterprise Development Programme Graduation Ceremony in the Garden Route District



On January 24, 2025, Sedfa hosted the Enterprise Development Coaching Programme Graduation Ceremony at Fancourt, George, celebrating the success of 21 local entrepreneurs who completed the 8-month coaching programme.

The ceremony featured speeches from key stakeholders and local dignitaries, recognizing top performers in business planning, attendance, and presentations. The keynote address by Garden Route District Municipality Executive Mayor, Andrew Stroebel, emphasized the value of community collaboration in achieving success.

Sedfa's Acting Provincial Manager, Kiewit Mhlongo, highlighted the program's role in developing management competencies and supporting economic growth in the George area.

The programme also provided tailored support in business strategies, networking, innovation, and access to Sedfa programs, helping local entrepreneurs enhance their skills and grow their businesses.

A similar programme was held in Cape Town on December 5, 2023, at La Romantica, Meerendal Wine Estate.

PMB SECP Programme Graduation

At least 33 graduates of the Sedfa Enterprise Coaching Programme (SECP) celebrated their achievements at a ceremony held on 4 February 2025 at Golden Horse Casino, Pietermaritzburg. Over ten months, participants received coaching in strategic planning, financial management, and business operations.



Keynote speaker Mark Gounder, CEO of Hulamin, encouraged entrepreneurs to pursue consistent growth. The programme saw significant results, including a 193% increase in profits, 90 new jobs created, and R211 million in total turnover generated by participants. Graduates expressed gratitude to Sedfa for the opportunity and pledged to apply their newly acquired skills to their businesses.

Sedfa's SECP in Pietermaritzburg provided targeted coaching and skills development for entrepreneurs over ten months. The intervention culminated in a Dragons' Den event where participants



pitched to financiers, securing potential funding opportunities.

The programme, adapted from Belgium's SAPLATO model, saw entrepreneurs achieve remarkable growth:

- 64% increase in turnover
- 18% job growth (90 new jobs created)
- 193% increase in profits
- 55% rise in asset value



Award-winning entrepreneur Deu Leslie Kekana credited the programme for helping him secure a lucrative contract with Eskom. The event highlighted Sedfa's ongoing commitment to empowering SMEs and driving economic transformation.

SECP launch NW – Klerksdorp **Sedfa Launches Enterprise Coaching Programme to Elevate Small Business Competitiveness**

Klerksdorp, South Africa – 13 March 2025 – Sedfa is proud to announce the launch of its latest Enterprise Coaching Programme in Dr Kenneth Kaunda District, aimed at enhancing the competitiveness and sustainability of small businesses. This initiative continues as Sedfa's commitment to empowering small and medium-sized enterprises (SMMEs) through structured coaching.

The programme is based on the internationally recognised SAPLATO methodology, originally developed in Belgium and tailored to meet the unique needs of South African entrepreneurs. SAPLATO is designed to bring together

groups of business owners under the guidance of experienced professionals from large corporations, fostering mentorship, knowledge-sharing, and business growth.



Programme Overview

The Klerksdorp Sedfa Coaching Programme will span 10 months, engaging 30 SMMEs across the district. Each participating business will benefit from:

- Ten interactive coaching sessions, facilitated by an expert coach.
- Specialist guest speakers sharing insights on key business challenges and opportunities.
- A collaborative peer-learning environment, where businesses can network, exchange experiences, and apply new strategies.
- Practical implementation, with participants reporting progress, challenges, and successes in subsequent sessions.

Objectives & Expected Impact

This initiative is designed to equip small business owners with the tools and guidance needed to drive growth, efficiency, and compliance. The key focus areas include:

- Increasing turnover through strategic business development.
- Job retention and creation, fostering



economic sustainability.

- Enhancing operational efficiency and effectiveness to improve business performance.
- Strengthening compliance with regulatory and statutory requirements.

Driving Economic Growth through Mentorship

By leveraging expert coaching and peer-to-peer learning, the Sedfa Enterprise Coaching Programme aims to accelerate the success of local businesses, ensuring that they are better positioned for long-term sustainability. Global Mark (Pty) Ltd led by Ilana Marnewecke and

Rehab Ngoasheng will be implementing the coaching programme with Ilana Marnewecke as the qualified coach to serve as lead mentor.



Small Enterprise Export Development Programme



In the spirit of Human Rights Month, Leaders in Motion Academy (LiMA) stands as a beacon of liberation for township-based creative entrepreneurs. As one of South Africa's pioneering digital creative skills academies and production hubs, LiMA is actively dismantling the legacy of inequality by providing vital digital and business skills in gaming and film production. We are forging pathways that connect these talented individuals to the vast opportunities of African and

global markets, enabling them to fully realize their creative potential, said Thato Molamu.

LiMA, a SETA accredited film and video production hub, delivers practical training skills for entrepreneurs in filmmaking, echoing the freedom to create and express. The hub provides business incubation support, facilities, and training, nurturing emerging film entrepreneurs and enterprises within



previously disadvantaged communities – communities that were once denied the very freedoms we now celebrate. We are actively writing a new chapter of a free democratic country, filled with endless economic opportunities.



Thato Molamo, the managing director of LiMA, articulates this vision: 'In this Human Rights Month, we declare that no longer will a young black child from the township, with a dream to become a game developer or filmmaker, struggle to learn how to create a film or develop a video game. We're breaking down barriers for township youth, ensuring they gain the essential entrepreneurial skills previously out of reach. We empower them to not only own, but also actively market and distribute their unique African creative content, transforming their aspirations into tangible, sustainable businesses and giving birth to their long-held dreams.' Speaking at the Henley Business School Alumni Programme, which explored various aspects of game development in South Africa, Thato emphasized the importance of changing how our stories are told, especially as African and colored people, reclaiming our narrative – a fundamental act of freedom.

While attending GAMESCOM-DEVCOM in Cologne, Germany, through the Small Business Export Development Programme (SBED), funded by the Department of Small Business Development (DSBD) and Small Enterprise Development and Finance Agency, Sedfa, LiMA's founder articulated

the objective: to support youth in film and gaming, to create representation, and to drive access for previously disadvantaged youth, while promoting gaming, animation, virtual reality(vr), infrastructure needs, and increasing visibility for smaller studios to a global audience and investors.

LiMA continues to raise awareness using film and versatile content strategies to drive investment and grow the culture of gaming, animation, VR, and Unreal Engine in the digital economy, enabling us to compete globally and export our stories to global markets. Our locally produced content is a vital expression of our cultural freedom, it serves as our unique brand, one that we should wear with pride.

LiMA expressed gratitude for the opportunity granted by "Small Business Export Development Programme (SBED)" in partnership with "Small Enterprise Development and Finance Agency (Sedfa), by giving us exposure to a global stage, recognizing the freedom to participate in the global economy. The international market needs to realize the value in buying locally developed games and develop interest in watching local content that reflects our country's diversity and opportunities.

“ Our objective as LiMA is to showcase the collaboration between industries, demonstrating that one needs the other to grow.”

Newer industries require a 360-degree approach, agility, and more flexible support by the national government to enable high-speed growth. Hence, opportunities provided by Sedfa, SBED, and DSBD continue to champion the growth of emerging markets and new industries, ensuring that the promise of freedom extends to economic and creative empowerment, concludes Thato.



Pitch for Funding Programme

[Click Here to watch the National Presidential Awards \(Pitch for Funding\)](#)

Pitch for Funding Competition – A National Platform for Innovation
As one of Sedfa's most significant events, the Pitch for Funding Competition brought together MSMEs from all provinces, providing them with a unique opportunity to compete for funding and mentorship.

The competition unfolded in multiple stages:

Pitch & Perfect Masterclass



To ensure that MSMEs were well-prepared for their presentations, a series of focused training sessions were conducted in the lead-up to the competition. Led by experienced training specialists, these sessions provided entrepreneurs with the necessary tools to mentally prepare, build confidence, and refine their pitching skills.

The Pitch & Perfect Masterclass focused on:

- Effective Communication – Teaching

entrepreneurs how to articulate their business vision clearly and persuasively.

- Managing Nerves Under Pressure – Equipping participants with strategies to remain composed and professional during their pitches.
- Personalized Feedback – Offering tailored advice to strengthen each entrepreneur's delivery and business case.

By the time the Pitch for Funding Competition commenced, participants had honed their skills, allowing them to showcase their business ideas with clarity and impact. This holistic support significantly boosted their confidence and maximized their chances of success.

- **District-Level Competitions** – MSMEs pitched their ideas at local Sedfa branches.
- **Provincial Competitions** – The best enterprises advanced to compete at provincial level.
- **National Finals** – Top-performing

MSMEs from each province competed for prestigious awards and funding support. Throughout the competition, entrepreneurs demonstrated exceptional creativity and resilience, making a compelling case on why their businesses deserved investment.

The winners in each category earned national recognition and financial support, at the National Presidential MSME & Cooperatives Awards under the theme Celebrating Excellence. These awards recognized outstanding businesses across various categories, celebrating their innovation, resilience, and contribution to the South African economy enabling them to scale their businesses and drive economic transformation in their communities.



The winners announced at the national awards ceremony on 22 November 2024 are :

- **Start-Up Business of the Year** – Dimakatso Kanyanene of Dillets (Mpumalanga)
- **Business in Development of the Year** – Photolo Thapelo of Inter Lab (Free State)
- **Homegrown MSME of the Year** – Mothabi Tebello of AWRE Resilient Tar (Gauteng)

Primary Co-operative Limited (Limpopo)

- **Best Performing Urban CBI of the Year** – Nyanda Delisile of Ndlovukazi yakwaZulu Women Financial Services Primary Co-operative Limited (KwaZulu-Natal)
- **Best Performing Rural CBI of the Year** – Jaxa Ntomb'nkulu of Imvelo Agricultural Cooperative (Eastern Cape)
- **Breaking Ground MSME of the**



Pitch for Funding winners announced at the National Presidential Awards 2024

- **Rural-Based MSME of the Year** – Thando Zwane of Sthaweni Farming (Gauteng)
- **Township MSME of the Year** – Segole Kedibone of Moipone Aesthetics (Gauteng)
- **Youth-Led MSME of the Year** – Brian Gadisi of Arion Power (Western Cape)
- **Women-Led MSME of the Year** – Cate Olifant of Akani Paints (Limpopo)
- **Social Enterprise of the Year** – Jamie Wyngaard of Loop Taxi App (Western Cape)
- **Cooperative of the Year** – Sithole Njabulo of Sizanobuhle Cooperative (KwaZulu-Natal)
- **Best Employing Cooperative of the Year** – Mabasa Basani of Tananani Matiko Disabled Multi-Purpose

Year – Visser Brendan of PBBTV and Productions (Western Cape)

- **MSME Owned by a Person with Disabilities** – Motshophi Lachracia of Motshophi Enterprise & Supply Chain Solution (Limpopo)

“These exceptional businesses have demonstrated remarkable resilience, innovation, and entrepreneurial excellence, setting a high standard for future generations of MSMEs.”

AWARDS, EVENTS & MORE

Tshwane Women in Business Awards (TWIBA)



Six Sedfa-supported MSMEs walking away with prestigious prizes



The Tshwane Women in Business Awards (TWIBA) 2023 took an innovative approach, going beyond just recognizing women-owned businesses to providing them with tangible support. The program equipped entrepreneurs with essential tools of trade, including computers, tablets, data packages, and business-relevant skills to enhance their operational efficiency and competitiveness.

Through this impactful initiative, over 30 businesses benefited from various forms of support, further reinforcing the commitment to empowering women entrepreneurs.

The Sedfa Tshwane Branch, together with its clients, was honored to participate in the TWIBA Awards, which took place on Tuesday, 26 November 2024, at the Ditsong National Museum of

Cultural History in Pretoria. The ongoing collaboration between TWIBA, Sedfa, and African Bank continues to foster entrepreneurial growth and provide much-needed resources to women-led MSMEs.

An Exciting and Insightful Event
This dynamic and inspiring event celebrated the achievements of women entrepreneurs, with six Sedfa-supported MSMEs walking away with prestigious prizes. These included spa sessions and cash prizes, generously sponsored by African Bank, to further support their businesses.

In addition to financial incentives, these entrepreneurs continue to benefit from Sedfa's ongoing business development support, mentorship, and promotional opportunities, ensuring sustainable growth and long-term success.



Sedfa Celebrates International Women's Day in Grand Style



Sedfa Board Chairperson, Ms Makanda opened the event by sharing the Purpose of the Day



The Director General of the Department of Small Business Development, Ms Manzini gave the Key Note Address

[Click Here to Watch the Event](#)



Sedfa in partnership with Women of Value South Africa (WOVSA) and the European Union Funded Ecosystem Development for Small Enterprises (EDSE), celebrated International Women's Day at Sandton Hotel, on the 27th March 2025, featuring impactful discussions under the theme "For ALL Women and Girls: Rights. Equality. Empowerment."

The event began with a keynote address by Ms Thulisile Manzini, Director-General of the DSBD, who highlighted the department and Sedfa's impact over the years. "In the past 5 years, over 130,000 women-owned businesses have accessed critical financial and non-financial support through former sefa and Seda," she declared.

The programme also included three panel discussions on issues that impact women.

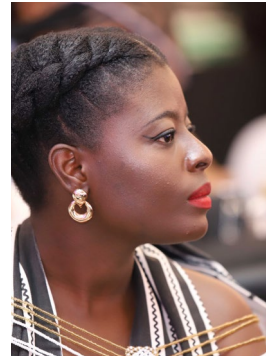
The first panel explored Business Development, Support Programmes, and International Opportunities for Women, with contributions from diplomats, government officials, and business leaders from Ghana, Nigeria, Lesotho, and South Africa.

The second panel focused on Funding Programmes for Women Entrepreneurs, featuring experts from Sedfa, Old Mutual Masisizane Fund, and Studio LLC. Sedfa was represented by Ms Marilyn Phetoe who explained Sedfa's offerings.

The final panel discussion was a Women in Leadership Dialogue, featuring high-ranking executives from Afreximbank, OWIT Zimbabwe, and WOVSA.

The day concluded with key announcements on the Sedfa Women Desk and WOVSA's Interprovincial Trade Roadshows.





DSBD Initiatives

SEIF Launch



Minister Stella Tembisa Ndabeni launches the Shared Economic Infrastructure Facilities (SEIF)



Minister Stella Tembisa Ndabeni was in Ekurhuleni on the 7th March to present a R14,950,000.00 Shared Economic Infrastructure Facilities (SEIF) to the Raco Holdings-Manufacturing Supplier Park Project in Ekurhuleni Metropolitan Municipality to MSMEs.

“ This initiative aimed to **provide co-funding for shared infrastructure facilities** to support Micro, Small, and Medium Enterprises (MSMEs).”

The project focused on renovating and expanding the existing Raco Holdings site to create a shared facility for 4-6 MSMEs. Local MSMEs will benefit from the upgraded site, gaining access to critical infrastructure such as workshops and warehousing facilities. This unique concept is expected to boost economic growth for MSMEs and Gauteng's economic revival whilst uplifting small enterprises.

SEIF is one of the support measures to encourage partnership between national, provincial and local government to accelerate public and private sector investment through a provision of necessary economic infrastructure for small enterprises to unlock greater economic growth.

MARKET ACCESS

Pop-Up Markets

POP-UP Market Western Cape



In a vibrant showcase of innovation and community spirit, an exciting Pop Up market was held at Maynard Mall in Wynberg from 28-29 March 2025. It featured an impressive lineup of 12 clients, each representing the heart and soul of local entrepreneurship.

The pop-up market provided a unique platform for SMMEs to display their products and services, ranging from artisanal crafts and handmade jewellery to delicious local cuisine and innovative tech solutions. Attendees were greeted with a warm atmosphere filled with the sounds of live music and the enticing aromas of freshly prepared food, creating an inviting space for community engagement.

One of the standout vendors was Msi Shoe Shine, known for their quality leather belts, bags and sandals made from recycled tyres. Their commitment to sustainability resonated with many visitors, showcasing how small enterprises can contribute positively to the environment while providing beautiful products.



**POP-UP
market**
show your love for local brands

The pop-up market not only allowed these MSMEs to gain exposure but also fostered connections between entrepreneurs and the local community. This collaborative environment encouraged the exchange of ideas and strategies, reinforcing the importance of community support in nurturing small businesses.

Sedfa's initiative aligns with its mission to empower small enterprises and promote economic growth. By providing a platform for local entrepreneurs to thrive, they are helping to create sustainable job opportunities and stimulate the local economy. As the event came to a close, many vendors reported strong sales and valuable connections made with potential customers and partners. The success of the pop-up market demonstrates the resilience and creativity of Wynberg's small business community.

The event was not just a marketplace; it was a celebration of local talent and entrepreneurial spirit. Events like these play a crucial role in uplifting small businesses and fostering a sense of community, proving that when small businesses thrive, everyone benefits. We look forward to more such initiatives that bring together the best of local entrepreneurship in the future!



Dr. Kenneth Kaunda Pop-Up Market, Northwest

Date: 7 Dec 2024

On 7 December 2024, Sedfa Dr. KK Northwest, in partnership with the Department of Social Development and JB Marks Municipality, hosted a pop-up market in Ventersdorp for 30 MSMEs. The event provided a platform for local entrepreneurs to showcase and sell their products, attracting a significant number of customers and fostering economic development.

Pre-exhibition training was offered to participating MSMEs, helping them refine their business skills.

“We are thrilled with the success of this market,” said Kedibone Nchwe, Information Officer at Sedfa Dr. KK. “It highlights the importance of collaboration in supporting local entrepreneurship.”



Pop-Up Market in Makhado, Limpopo

Date: 28-29 Mar 2025

Small Enterprise Development and Finance Agency (Sedfa) in partnership with Makhado Crossing mall hosted a two(2) day Pop-up Market at Makhado Crossing in Makhado, Vhembe District, Limpopo on 28 – 29 March.

The partnership was the continuation of a similar initiative that the two(2) entities organized in the previous financial year, 2023/24. The resounding success of the event held in March 2023 at the same venue, inspired both entities to join hands again to bring together MSME's around



the district to come and exhibit their products and services.

The event which was hosted under the theme **“show your love for local brands”** saw 21 exhibitors, setting up their stalls to sell their products and services and more importantly promoting their brands. The MSMEs were carefully selected based on the sectors and products and services offerings. The Sedfa local branch ensured that the right clients with ready-to-sell products and services are given the opportunity to exhibit.

The support from the mall to make the event a success was unimaginable; the mall provided free exhibition space for the duration of the event. Furthermore, the Mall procured gazebos, tables and chairs for the exhibition.

This partnership is a testimony that working together with the private sector, means that we can do even more for our clients and entrepreneurs across the length and breadth of the country.



[Words of appreciation and testimony by the clients]

One of the entrepreneurs exhibiting at the event, **Ms. Gundo Mureri, could not contain her excitement about taking part in the exhibition.** She was grateful to Sedfa and the Makhado Mall for giving her the rare opportunity to promote her business to a bigger market.

Ms. Mureri manufactures her own detergent; however due to lack of access to markets, her business was not making enough sales; **but through the pop-up market, where she had a large number of people visiting her stall and buying,** she is convinced that things will improve and that her business will grow.

Makhado Mall was equally satisfied with how the event went and is confident that it will contribute towards its BEE target and social responsibility to the Makhado community. The two(2) entities indicated that they want to continue with the partnership in the near future by hosting a business seminar where different ecosystem stakeholders and partners (private and public) will be invited to come and present their entities' products and services, and the support they have available for entrepreneurs and aspiring MSME's.



Festivals



Lemo Fest

Sedfa supported fashionpreneurs showcase at the Lemo Fest Qoai Fashion Show

The 5th annual Lemo Festival took place at Bloemfontein's Lemo Mall Green Park, offering a vibrant mix of music, business exhibitions, and fashion. Sedfa Free State facilitated the participation of 22 MSMEs, providing a platform for them to engage with entrepreneurial giants like DJ Sbu, Vusi Thembekwayo, Laduma of Amakhosa and Carol Bouwer to name a few.

Business masterclasses and networking opportunities helped the local entrepreneurs gain valuable insights. Sedfa Free State's Provincial Manager, Ms Jackie Ntshingila emphasized the need for knowledge-sharing and market access to empower entrepreneurs. The festival remains a vital initiative for township revitalization and local economic development in the Free State.



Kota Festival

The Kota festival was held at Phuthaditjhaba Park on the 5th October 2024. The Festival, organized by the QwaQwa Kota Association in partnership with Sedfa, Standard Bank, and Thabo Mofutsanyana Sports, Arts, and Culture, celebrated local street cuisine. The second edition of this festival saw 28 vendors offering a variety of products, from ice cream to traditional kota dishes. The event aims to become an annual celebration, bringing families together to enjoy authentic kasi cuisine while providing local food entrepreneurs with greater market access.



ISO 9001:2015 Training Empowers Manufacturing Businesses

The Sedfa Tshwane Branch successfully hosted an ISO 9001:2015 training session to support clients in the manufacturing sector. This initiative aimed to enhance businesses' understanding of quality management systems (QMS) and equip them with the necessary tools to meet international accreditation standards.

Recognizing the critical role of structured training in business development, the Learning Academy, as the custodian of training within the organization, appointed Mrs. Rosslyn Dlamini, a champion of business accreditation, to facilitate the session.

The ISO 9001:2015 standard, developed by the International Organization for Standardization (ISO), **provides a framework for organizations to consistently deliver high-quality products and services that meet customer expectations while improving overall satisfaction.**

This training complements other business development initiatives such as Entrepreneurship Training and participation in The Africa Tourism Indaba where Leonora Holiday Travel has benefitted.

Leonora Holiday Travel

Leonora Holiday Travel, a growing agency, sought Sedfa's assistance in expanding its operations. After undergoing business plan optimization training



Participants that attended and completed the ISO 9001:2015 training



and entrepreneurship workshops, the company received marketing support, including a promotional video featured across Sedfa platforms. Sedfa will furthermore assist in supporting the businesses in achieving compliance and enhancing operational efficiency. This includes assisting with Quick Tickets, CRM integration, and AITA compliance to foster sustainable business growth.

[Click here to view Leonora promotional video](#)

Empowering MSMEs with Disabilities

The Sedfa disability event that was held on 18 March 2025 in Kuruman, served as a pipeline for Sedfa according to John Taolo Gaetsewe (who is he?) to attract aspirant entrepreneurs and business owners living with disabilities.

Speaking briefly about the purpose of the event, the Marketing Specialist Ms. Bongiwé Thatelo, for Sedfa NC, indicated that the event was held under the banner of the International Day for people with disabilities which was celebrated on 3 December 2024. "Although the day was celebrated three months ago, we were not discouraged because this programme forms part of Sedfa's sector specific events. Therefore, we are here to reaffirm our commitment to support differently abled entrepreneurs" said Ms. Thatelo.

In addition, Ms. Thatelo highlighted that the main aim of the event was to raise awareness about the new entity and its bouquet of financial and non-financial solutions for micro, small and medium enterprises, including cooperatives.

As she delved into her presentation on financial solutions, Sedfa's Investment Officer, Ms. Landiwe Daka, shared information on the Amavulandlela Funding Scheme. According to Ms. Daka, this scheme was established solely for entrepreneurs with disabilities and in response to skyrocketing levels of poverty and unemployment among this community. "The scheme offers persons with disabilities an opportunity to enter the mainstream economy by accessing credit facilities ranging from R50 000.00 to a maximum of R15 million" stated Ms. Daka.



Mr. Tumisang Molale from the National Youth Development Agency also placed emphasis on the critical role NYDA plays in supporting young entrepreneurs with disabilities. As specified by Mr. Molale, NYDA provides young entrepreneurs with grants ranging from R1 000.00 to R 200 000.00 with higher amounts available for agriculture and technology-related projects. Apart from this, NYDA offers mentorship programs and consultancy services to guide young entrepreneurs through the complexities of running a business. "We also provide training programs to improve business management skills, ensuring that entrepreneurs can effectively manage their enterprises" said Mr. Molale.

The positive reviews from attendees proved that besides sharing of invaluable information, the event was impactful. Here's what some of them had to say: A small business owner, Ms. Pholoso Ralehike said, "This event has opened my eyes to the numerous support programmes available. I feel more confident about the future of my business and the potential for growth".

Ms. Nancy Segopolo, a participant in the construction sector, noted the following. "Learning about the small enterprise support programme was invaluable. The technical skills and financial support will help elevate my business to new heights."



CO-OPERATIVES

2024 Cooperative Banking Indaba: A Catalyst for Local Economic Development

The 2024 Cooperative Banking Indaba, held from October 15 to 17, 2024, in collaboration with the Gauteng Department of Economic Development (GDED), focused on the theme: “Co-operative Banking Institutions as Financial Intermediaries of Choice for Local Economic Development and Growth.” This theme highlighted the pivotal role that Cooperative Banking Institutions (CBIs) can play in financing local economic development to address socio-economic challenges such as small enterprise funding, unemployment, and poverty.

The Indaba attracted over 200 delegates, including stakeholders and regulators from various organizations such as BANKSETA, DGRV, Rhodes University, National Treasury, World Bank, UNISA, DSBD, ESASCCO, NDA, CIPC, FSCA, NCR, and the Prudential Authority.



Key Presentations

1. National Treasury: Fostering financial inclusion through Co-operative Banking.
2. Rhodes University: Research on South African Co-operative Banking Development: Local Context and Global Insights.
3. Retail Bonds Division, National Treasury: Investment options for the sector.
4. Sector Representatives: Overview of the sector in five provinces.

Commissions and Recommendations

Four commissions addressed key challenges in the sector, providing suggestions and recommendations:

1. **Financial Inclusion and Local Economic Development:** CBIs play a crucial role in promoting financial inclusion and socio-economic growth. Despite governance and capacity challenges, they have significant potential to impact job creation and poverty reduction through innovative strategies and community-focused approaches.
2. **Digitisation:** Digitisation presents both challenges and opportunities for the cooperative banking sector. By addressing barriers such as limited resources and regulatory constraints, CBIs can leverage digital tools to enhance operational efficiency, member engagement, and sustainable banking practices. Digital literacy programs and collaboration among CBIs are crucial for successful digitisation and expanding access to

financial services for underbanked and rural communities.

3. Regulatory Environment: Over-regulation, reporting inefficiencies, and high compliance costs are significant challenges. Solutions proposed include streamlining processes, improving regulatory compliance, and enhancing sector growth through digitisation, better reporting systems, and inclusive deposit insurance. Collaboration among CBIs and leveraging legislative opportunities are also emphasized to support sustainable development and job creation.

4. Strategic Business Growth and Resilience: The importance of strategic business growth, resilience, and the integration of new technologies in the cooperative banking sector was highlighted. A balanced regulatory environment, capacity building, and financial education are essential for sustainability and competitiveness. Partnerships, income diversification, and effective crisis management strategies are also crucial for the sector's growth and resilience.

Gala Dinner and Awards

The Indaba concluded with a gala dinner celebrating the top performers in the sector:

• **Best Three CFIs:**

1. Medicoop Co-operative Financial Institution
2. Ndlovukazi YakwaZulu Co-operative Financial Institution
3. Nagrik SA Financial Co-operative

• **Overall Co-operative Bank winner:**

Ziphakamise Co-operative Bank

The 2024 Cooperative Banking Indaba underscored the vital role of CBIs in driving local economic development and addressing socio-economic challenges. The event fostered collaboration, shared insights, and proposed actionable strategies to enhance the sector's impact and sustainability.



AgroLift: A Strategic Initiative for Agricultural Advancement

The Sedfa Research & Development team has launched AgroLift, an innovative and strategically structured agricultural support programme currently being piloted in the Eastern Cape and Free State. Rooted in extensive market analysis, this initiative is designed to empower small-scale farmers and agribusinesses by addressing systemic challenges related to resource accessibility, financial inclusion, and market integration.



The conceptualization of AgroLift was directly informed by a recently concluded market segmentation study conducted by Sedfa Research. This study provided a nuanced understanding of the constraints impeding the growth of small agricultural enterprises.

“Key challenges identified included **limited access to finance, inadequate infrastructure, and barriers to market entry.**”

The findings underscored the necessity for a segmented and data-driven support framework, ensuring that interventions are tailored to the specific needs of distinct agricultural sub-sectors, rather than applying a one-size-fits-all approach.

Agriculture remains a cornerstone of Sedfa's strategic priorities, given its competitive advantage across multiple provinces and its significant potential to drive rural economic development, job creation, and food security. Recognizing this, AgroLift has been meticulously structured to foster the sustainable growth of small agricultural enterprises through targeted, high-impact interventions.

To achieve this, AgroLift incorporates a multi-faceted, evidence-based intervention model encompassing the following key pillars:

- **Segmented Business Development Support** – Catering to the distinct growth trajectories of agricultural enterprises, the programme offers tailored interventions from early-stage development to expansion and commercialization.

- **Resource Accessibility and Infrastructure Development** – Participating farmers will benefit from subsidized agricultural inputs, shared-use post-harvest storage and processing facilities, irrigation solutions, and access to advanced precision-farming technologies to enhance efficiency and productivity.
- **Capacity Building and Skills Enhancement** – Through specialized training in digital literacy, financial management, sustainable farming methodologies, and market competitiveness, the programme equips farmers with the requisite expertise to thrive in a dynamic agricultural landscape.
- **Financial Inclusion and Risk Mitigation** – To enhance financial resilience and economic stability, AgroLift facilitates access to microfinance and tailored investment-readiness training those safeguards farmers against production risks.
- **Market Access and Value Chain Integration** – The programme seeks to strengthen farmers' integration into high-value markets by fostering cooperative development, facilitating contractual engagements with major buyers, and supporting brand positioning strategies at both national and international levels.
- **Sustainability and Climate Resilience** – Acknowledging the escalating impact of climate change on agricultural productivity, AgroLift actively promotes climate-smart farming techniques, organic certification frameworks, and innovative waste-to-energy solutions to enhance environmental sustainability.

With the pilot phase well underway, the next crucial step is finalizing the programme's design and engaging

key sectoral stakeholders—including government departments, financial institutions, agribusiness corporations, and development agencies—to optimize implementation and ensure long-term scalability.



By leveraging data-driven insights from the recently concluded market segmentation study, Sedfa is poised to establish a transformative support ecosystem that fosters sustainable agricultural development, enhances food security, and strengthens economic resilience among smallholder farmers,” stated Mr. Mduduzi Dlamini, Sedfa’s Research and Development Manager.

As AgroLift continues to evolve, it will serve as a benchmark for evidence-based, impact-driven agricultural transformation, ensuring that smallholder farmers and agribusinesses are not merely sustained but empowered to thrive within an increasingly complex and competitive global economy.

Stay informed for forthcoming updates on this pioneering initiative!



AMATHUBA

PROVIDING
OPPORTUNITIES



www.sedfa.org.za

A **Sedfa** Publication